



SCHOLARSHIP NEGOTIATION TOOLKIT

Proven Email Templates, Timing Strategies, and Leverage
Tactics
to Increase Your Scholarship Offer

IvyAmbition

T14 Law School Admissions Consulting



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CHAPTER 01

Why Negotiation Works

Most law school applicants accept their first scholarship offer without negotiating. They assume the offer is final, that asking for more is rude, or that the school will rescind the offer entirely if they push back. **None of these assumptions are true.**

Law schools expect negotiation. They build it into their financial aid budgets. The initial offer is almost never the best offer they can make. It is the offer they make knowing that most people won't ask for more.

\$5,000 – \$50,000

The average additional scholarship money received by applicants who negotiate vs. those who don't. Some receive full-tuition offers after initially being offered half-tuition. The difference between asking and not asking can be **six figures in debt.**

CHAPTER 02

Understanding Your Leverage

Leverage comes from one thing: **credible alternatives**. A school increases your scholarship when they believe you might attend a competing school instead.

Tier 1: Peer School Offer

Strongest leverage. Michigan offers \$90K, UVA offers \$150K — Michigan has strong incentive to match or close the gap. Peer = within ~5 ranking positions.

Tier 2: Higher-Ranked School Offer

Mentioning a Columbia offer to Penn signals you're a candidate top schools want. May not match the number but can move the needle.

Tier 3: Lower-Ranked School with Much More Money

Works when the dollar gap is dramatic. Georgetown full-tuition (\$180K+) vs NYU's \$40K — NYU may increase because losing you to Georgetown over money hurts their yield.

Tier 4: No Competing Offer, Genuine Need

Weakest but still worth trying. Financial aid offices have discretionary funds. Demonstrate genuine hardship. Works better at access-focused schools.

CHAPTER 03

The Negotiation Playbook

1

Collect All Offers First

Do not negotiate with your first offer. Wait until you have at least 3-4 scholarship decisions. If a deposit deadline approaches before you've heard from others, email that school and ask for a 2-4 week extension. Most grant them routinely.

2

Organize Your Offers

Create a spreadsheet: school name, ranking, total scholarship, cost after scholarship, competing school for negotiation, and your honest preference if money were equal.

3

Send Your Negotiation Email

Email the **financial aid office**, not admissions. They have budget authority. If a formal reconsideration process exists, follow it exactly. Otherwise, use the template below.

4

Wait and Follow Up

Most schools respond in 1-3 weeks. After 2 weeks with no response, send one brief follow-up. Do not follow up more than once.

5

Evaluate the Response

Three outcomes: (1) They increase it — evaluate the new number. (2) They say no — your original offer stands. (3) They ask for a call — good sign, they're considering it seriously.

✉ THE NEGOTIATION EMAIL TEMPLATE

Subject: Scholarship Reconsideration Request — [Your Name], [LSAC Number]

Dear [Financial Aid Office],

Thank you for admitting me to [School] and for the generous scholarship of [amount]. I am very excited about [School] and it remains one of my top choices.

I am writing to respectfully request reconsideration. I have received a scholarship of [competing amount] from [Competing School], and while [School] is my strong preference for [1-2 specific genuine reasons], the funding gap presents a significant financial challenge.

I would be grateful for any additional support that would allow me to attend [School] without the financial burden the current gap creates. I am fully committed to attending if the package makes it feasible.

Sincerely,
[Your Name] · [LSAC Number] · [Phone]

CHAPTER 04

Timing Your Negotiation

✓ **BEST: March through mid-April**

Most offers arrive Jan–March. By March you have enough offers. Schools want to lock in classes before deposit deadlines, so they're most responsive now.

✗ TOO EARLY: January with only one offer. No leverage yet.

✗ TOO LATE: Late April after first deposit deadline. Less budget, less incentive.

→ **DEADLINE PRESSURE?** Ask for an extension: "I am very interested in [School] and am finalizing my financial aid with another institution. Would a 2-week extension on the deposit deadline be possible?" Most schools grant this routinely.

CHAPTER 05

Advanced Tactics

1

The Specific Ask

Instead of "I'd appreciate any additional funding," try: "**Matching [School]'s offer of [specific amount] would make [Your School] my clear first choice.**" Specific asks are easier for offices to process and approve.

2

The Genuine Enthusiasm Play

Express specific reasons you prefer their school (clinics, professors, programs, family location). Schools give money to applicants who will **actually attend**. Yield matters to them.

3

The Second Negotiation

If they increase but don't match, you can negotiate again — but **only if** you've received a new, better competing offer since round one. Never renegotiate with the same information.

4

Non-Monetary Negotiation

If they can't increase scholarship: ask about RA positions, stipended fellowships, housing grants, bar exam fee coverage, or loan repayment assistance. These have real dollar value and are sometimes easier to offer.

5

The Conditional Commitment

"If [School] can match [Competitor]'s offer, I will commit immediately and withdraw all other applications." The strongest possible signal. **Only use if you mean it.** Schools respond because it eliminates yield risk.

WANT HELP WITH YOUR NEGOTIATION?

IvyAmbition offers Scholarship Negotiation Sessions where we review your offers, identify leverage, and craft your strategy and emails.

Book a free 15-minute consultation at ivyambition.com